# Right-Size Your Structure

How much structure a project needs as it grows from one team to many: just enough to stay safe, no more.

Run a Project · Inspired by Brooks's law (Fred Brooks), Scrum's small teams, SAFe's release trains and Team Topologies

PROJECT _____

DATE _____

## 1 One Team — LEVEL 1

### 3–10 people · 1 team

4 people: 6 links

**PLANNING**

A short planning conversation each iteration, and a simple roadmap.

**Sprint Planning · Prioritisation Board**

**ROLES**

A product owner or lead sets priorities; the team shares the rest.

**Team Charter**

**EVENTS**

Daily sync, planning, review and retro, kept short.

**Events & Cadences**

**TRACKING WORK**

One visible board. Conversation fills the gaps.

**Kanban Board Design**

**RISKS & DEPENDENCIES**

Raise them in the daily sync and planning; note the big ones.

**Pre-mortem**

**REPORTING**

Show working software at the review, plus a short note to the sponsor.

**Sprint Review**

**DECISIONS & GOVERNANCE**

Decide in the room. Write down only what people will ask about later.

**Team Charter (How We Decide)**

## 2 Team of Teams — LEVEL 2

### 10–50 people · 2–5 teams

40 people: 780 links

**PLANNING**

Plan together each planning period, with shared objectives.

**Cross-Team Planning · OKRs**

**ROLES**

Add a programme manager or RTE to coordinate, and one product lead across teams.

**RACI & Decision Log**

**EVENTS**

Add a weekly cross-team sync, a joint demo and a joint retro.

**Cross-Team Sync · Cross-Team Retro**

**TRACKING WORK**

A shared view of features across teams; each team keeps its own board.

**Dependency Map**

**RISKS & DEPENDENCIES**

A shared RAID log and dependency map, reviewed every week.

**RAID Log · Dependency Map**

**REPORTING**

A one-page outcome status report and a forecast range.

**Outcome Status Report · Release Forecast**

**DECISIONS & GOVERNANCE**

A decision log, a shared Definition of Done and clear decision rights.

**RACI & Decision Log · Delegation Board**

## 3 Programme — LEVEL 3

### 50+ people · many teams

120 people: 7,140 links

**PLANNING**

Outcomes set at the top; big-room planning for each group of teams.

**OKRs · Portfolio Kanban**

**ROLES**

Programme and portfolio leads, an RTE per group of teams, architecture and product leads.

**Team Topology Design**

**EVENTS**

Add portfolio reviews, and inspect & adapt across the whole programme.

**Events & Cadences · Value Metrics**

**TRACKING WORK**

A portfolio board of initiatives, with work in progress limited at the top.

**Portfolio Kanban & Investment Mix**

**RISKS & DEPENDENCIES**

Managed across groups of teams, with an owner at each level.

**RAID Log · Value Stream Map**

**REPORTING**

Outcome and value measures for leaders, rolled up from the same data.

**Value Metrics · Outcome Status Report**

**DECISIONS & GOVERNANCE**

Light governance: evidence from working software, risk-based approval, delegated decisions.

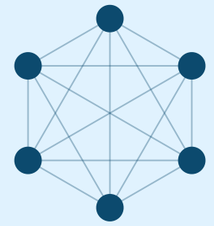
**SDLC at a Glance · Delegation Board · ADKAR**

## 4 Turn the Dial Up If... — SIZE ISN'T EVERYTHING

- [ ] High risk, safety or regulation
- [ ] Many dependencies on others
- [ ] A fixed date or contract
- [ ] Many stakeholders or senior visibility
- [ ] People across sites or time zones
- [ ] New team, domain or technology
- [ ] Long duration (many months)

*Two or more ticked? Borrow the next level's practices for those areas only.*

## 5 Coordination Grows Fast — LINKS = N × (N − 1) / 2



6 people: 15 links

| | |
|---|---|
| 4 people | **6 links** |
| 12 people | **66 links** |
| 40 people | **780 links** |
| 120 people | **7,140 links** |

## 6 Signs It's the Wrong Size

**TOO LITTLE**

- Surprises arrive late
- Teams block each other
- The same questions, again
- No one knows the plan

**TOO MUCH**

- Meetings about meetings
- Reports no one reads
- Decisions wait for sign-off
- Process for its own sake

*Add structure when it solves a problem you have; remove it when it doesn't.*

*"What's the least structure that would keep this project safe?"*

*"Which part of our process could we drop without anyone missing it?"*

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